Singh—without specifying 4.5 or 5th-gen jets—has said that the force needs to add 35-40 jets every year. The IAF's intense face-off with the Pakistan Air Force (PAF) during Operation Sindoor in May this year has driven home the gravity of the matter.

Now, in Vayu Bhawan, the IAF headquarters, discussions are going on about how to fill the combat gap. While a majority of experts believe in the acquisition of some fifth-gen jets to counter the China-Pakistan threat, a section strongly pitches for more Rafales to bring some uniformity in a varied inventory. In July, defence secretary R.K. Singh said that India is considering the option of buying fifth-gen fighters from "friendly countries". An Empowered Committee for Capability Enhancement of the IAF headed by Singh himself had identified key thrust areas and made recommendations in a report submitted to Union defence minister Rajnath Singh in March.

According to sources, the IAF has concluded after Operation Sindoor that despite the decisive edge provided by the Rafales, a notable challenge was to achieve perfect sensor fusion across domains—the hallmark of modern aerial combat—due to the lack of standardised data links across the force's diverse fleet of jets.

"It's a hard choice to make. Under the Trump regime, the US is unpredictable. They are pushing hard to sell 4th-gen jets like the F-16 or F-15E parked in their bases in West Asia before actually offering the F-35. If India needs to get 5th-gen jets as a stopgap arrangement, it should look towards Russia's Su-57," says Air Marshal Anil Chopra (retd). Another option, he adds, would be to go in for additional numbers of Rafales and support them with long-range air-to-air missiles.

F-35 VS SU-57

The American F-35 Lightning II and the Russian Su-57 Felon come with tall reputations. The F-35 stealth multirole fighter is one of the most advanced jets in operation and is backed by political signalling by US President Donald Trump, who proposed selling it to India in February. On the other hand, keen to preserve its long-standing defence ties with India, Russia has offered co-production of the Su-57 as well as sharing of technology—something that would appeal to New Delhi's Make in India ambitions. With national security advisor Ajit Doval and external affairs minister S. Jaishankar's separate visits to Moscow in August and President Vladimir Putin's expected trip to New Delhi in the coming months amid cooling India-US ties, geopolitical circumstances are tilted towards the Su-57.

The F-35 is priced at nearly $100 million (Rs 865 crore) a unit, while the Su-57 is around $65 million (Rs 562 crore) per jet. The Su-57 prioritises super manoeuvrability and multi-role capability, making it adept at bombing runs and long-range strikes. The F-35 focuses on sensor fusion, electronic warfare dominance and joint-force interoperability.

The F-35 has seen extensive operational deployment, with 17 countries procuring it. Israel has utilised it for strikes in Syria, while US forces rely on it for reconnaissance missions. In contrast, though combat-tested in Ukraine and Syria, the Su-57 has faced production delays and budget constraints, and is not yet mass-deployed by Russia.



"THE WEAPONS WITH THE IAF ARE UNFIT FOR USE IN INTERNAL WEAPONS BAYS OF THE F-35 AND THE SU-57. WE NEED TO FOCUS ON VERY HIGH FREQUENCY RADARS TO DETECT STEALTH AS WELL AS LOW RCS AIRCRAFT"

AIR MARSHAL S.B.P. SINHA (RETD)
Former Deputy Chief, IAF



MADE IN INDIA
A model of the indigenous 5th-gen jet, the AMCA, at Aero India 2025 in Bengaluru

A key IAF official explains that though the upfront cost of Russian platforms is low, their life-cycle cost is high. "While Su-57 is a maintenance-intensive jet with lesser upfront cost, F-35 is expensive with high turnaround time. But I doubt the US would sell India the same variant used by its own forces, as its export variant is a degraded one with potential limitations," he explains. However, with co-production and technology transfer on offer, New Delhi finds Su-57 a more viable option. "The estimated cost per unit of Su-57 ranges between$60-$75 million (Rs 519-648 crore) with production in India. This makes the Su-57 a more affordable option compared to the F-35," says a key defence official.

A section in the military favours buying more Rafale jets, though its price tag of nearly $170 million (over Rs 1,500 crore for a jet) is still an issue. The Rafale's advanced avionics and weapon systems make it ideal to counter emerging threats. Additional Rafale squadrons would enhance the IAF's strike capabilities. Moreover, inducting more Rafales would leverage the existing infrastructure and maintenance ecosystem, ensuring efficiency and cost-effectiveness.